



Anthropic Economic Index

How is AI impacting jobs and what it means for us

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From the panic that “AI will replace us,” to the optimism that “AI will set us free,” I’ve heard and seen it all since early 2023, just months after ChatGPT changed our world forever. And somewhere in between those extremes lies the uncomfortable truth we’re living through right now. Case in point is the newly released Anthropic Economic Index, a study by the creators of Claude (which competes with OpenAI’s ChatGPT) that attempts to measure AI’s real-world effect on employment and the job market overall. What it found is less about alarmist takeovers and more about subtle ways AI’s reshaping how we all earn a living – now and into the future. Below are five key learnings from the study that stood out for me.

AI will augment human ability

According to the Anthropic Economic Index, 57% of AI usage is about augmentation – that is helping humans complete tasks – while only 43% deals with outright automation. Instead of robots marching in to replace entire occupations, what we’re witnessing is more like the birth of a digital sidekick. That means if you’re a writer, maybe AI is helping you with rough drafts or grammar suggestions, rather than taking over your entire job. If you’re a customer service rep, it might handle routine FAQs, leaving you to handle the trickier, human-touch cases. What’s particularly telling is that the AI promise here isn’t about sacking armies of employees, but about offloading mundane tasks, and letting us focus on more creative or strategic work.

AI will break down jobs into tasks

The second key finding of the report is that analyzing entire jobs as a whole is misleading. The Index zeroes in on tasks within a role – like budgeting, drafting emails, or coding feature modules. Through this lens, AI might excel at a handful of tasks but falter at others, according to Anthropic. So, yes, an office assistant could rely on AI for scheduling and quick data analyses, but the same AI might struggle with a personal conversation that requires empathy or a complicated negotiation. This is a critical insight that should give us pause before we say “AI is taking over X job” ever in the future. In reality, it’s taking over certain tasks, while the rest remain in human hands. The future of work is, in large part, about picking which tasks can be offloaded and which remain purely ours to perform.

AI usage dominates the tech and media sector

Interestingly, the Index points out that AI usage is most prevalent in two main areas: “computer and mathematical” tasks (like coding) and creative fields (think writing and media). If you’ve scrolled the web lately, you’ve likely noticed a slew of AI-driven code completion tools, plus AI writing assistants churning out content for marketing sites or corporate blogs. This concentration also implies a future direction for AI adoption. If you’re in a more physical or interpersonal job – like a nurse or a chef – it’s less likely you’ll be replaced by AI tomorrow. But the creative and tech spaces are seeing a wave of partial automation. People there – myself included – are learning to integrate AI as a “second set of eyes,” or as a “junior developer” that solves straightforward tasks. **1**

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